



PSYC 1200: Foundations of Psychology

Fall 2026 | Section R04

Tuesdays & Fridays, 2:30–3:45 pm | [Location]

Instructor

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Office Hours

In person: Wednesdays 3:30-4:30 pm [Location]
 Remote:

Welcome to Foundations of Psychology

Psychology is everywhere. Whether you are studying marketing, theater, pre-law, education, economics, or psychology itself, understanding how people think, feel, and behave is one of the most transferable things you can learn in college. That is what this course is about.

Growing up in NYC, and later attending a PWI (**P**redominantly **W**hite Institution) for college, I noticed differences in how people related to one another, how groups formed, and how assumptions shaped interactions. That curiosity about how and why we think of others the way we do led me to where I am now: a Ph.D. candidate studying the cognitive underpinnings of bias and how our ideas about social groups develop over time.

My goal is not just to have you memorize theories. I want you to leave this course feeling like psychology gave you something useful, a new way of looking at a situation, a framework for understanding someone you disagree with, or just a genuine moment of "oh, that's why that happens." Psychology is richer, stranger, and more relevant than most people expect, and I look forward to exploring that together. Welcome to Foundations of Psychology.

Learning Objectives

The course provides a comprehensive survey of the facts, principles, and theories of psychology related to the following topics: the biological bases of mental processes and behavior; learning; sensation and perception; cognition; memory; language; motivation; developmental processes; personality; clinical psychology; and social psychology.

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Explain how psychology uses scientific methods to study behavior and mental processes, and evaluate the strengths and limitations of different research approaches.
- Identify and describe major concepts, theoretical perspectives, and empirical findings across core areas of psychology, including biological, cognitive, developmental, social, personality, and clinical psychology.
- Apply psychological principles to real-world issues, including decision-making, bias, stress, identity, and well-being.

- Think critically about psychological claims (including those you encounter in the media and everyday life) by weighing evidence, questioning assumptions, and recognizing limitations.
- Connect psychological science to your own experiences, interests, and future goals, whatever field you are headed into.

Textbook



Foundations of Psychology (via Noba Project). This is a free, open-access textbook edited by Fordham's Foundations instructors and available as a PDF on Blackboard. **No purchase required. Access the textbook here:** [anonymous link]

Additional required readings and supplemental materials will be posted on Blackboard as needed throughout the semester (see course calendar)

Course Structure



Lectures & Discussion

Class sessions will blend lecture, discussion, small-group work, and in-class activities. I will not be reading from slides for 75 minutes; I do not believe that is how learning works, and, honestly, it is not how I want to teach. You should expect to talk, think out loud, and engage with your peers. Bring your curiosity. Bring your questions. Bring your disagreements (respectfully, of course).

All slides and materials will be posted to Blackboard before each class. If you miss a session, it is your responsibility to get notes from a classmate and review the posted materials before the next class.



In-Class Activities

On many class days, we will do a brief, structured, graded activity (e.g., a short reflection, a small-group discussion, a poll, or a quick worksheet). These are low-stakes opportunities to engage with the material in real time and to show up as a participant in the course. Think of these as the heartbeat of the course; they are how I know we are actually in conversation, not just occupying the same room (*see Assignments & Assessments for grading criteria*).



Office Hours

Office hours are one of the most underused resources in any course. Come with questions about the material, about your assignments, about psychology more broadly, or about navigating college if that is what you need. I cannot help you if I do not know you are struggling, so please come to me early rather than late.

I will respond to emails within two business days. Please do not email me the night before an exam expecting an immediate reply; come to office hours before then instead. If you have questions about exams, please email me at least 2 days in advance to ensure I can respond.

Assignments & Assessments



Exams (45%)

There will be two midterm exams and one final exam. Each exam itself is worth 15% of your grade for a total of 45% of your overall grade. Exams are non-cumulative; each covers the material from its respective course block. Exam formats will include multiple-choice and short-answer questions. Study guides will be distributed in advance, and I encourage you to use office hours in the days leading up to each exam.

- Midterm 1: Session 12 (October 6) — covers Sessions 2–10
- Midterm 2: Session 23 (November 13) — covers Sessions 13–21
- Final Exam: Dec 15 — covers Sessions 24–27

If you miss an exam, a makeup will only be scheduled with an excused absence and advance notice. Without documentation, a missed exam cannot be made up.



Reading Quizzes (20%)

To help you stay on top of the readings and arrive at class prepared, there will be 12 multiple-choice only quizzes over the course of the semester. Quizzes open at the end of the last session on each topic and are due the following Sunday by 11:59 pm (see course calendar). Quizzes are completed on Blackboard. **They are open-note, but must be completed independently. Quizzes are also timed. AI tools are not allowed for quiz completion (see AI policy).**

Your lowest 2 quiz scores will be dropped. *No makeup quizzes will be given, but the drop policy is designed to accommodate unexpected circumstances without requiring documentation for a missed quiz.*



In-Class Activities (10%)

Throughout the semester, we will run more in-class activities than are required for full credit, so missing one here or there will not impact your grade. **Activities are graded on completion; if you are present and engage genuinely, you get credit. There will be 16 in-class activities across the semester. To obtain full points, you must complete at least 13 of these.** Because these activities cannot be made up outside of class, they also serve as your primary measure of engagement and attendance (see Attendance Policy).



Psychology in the World — Group Project (15%)

One of the things I want you to leave this course with is the ability to see psychology operating in real life, not just in textbooks. The group project is your opportunity to do that.

You will work in groups of 5 students.

Project Description: Your group identifies a real-world example of a psychological concept or phenomenon we have covered in class, from a film, TV show, news story, social media trend, historical event, or personal experience. You analyze it through a psychological lens: What concept does this illustrate? What does the research say? What does this example reveal or complicate? Your presentation should teach the class something and spark discussion.

Presentations will take place during Sessions 28 and 29. Each group will have approximately 12–15 minutes, plus 3–5 minutes for discussion. **A topic proposal, draft slides, and final slides are each required milestones with late penalties (see course schedule).**

Group project grade breakdown: 15% group deliverable (presentation + slides), 5% individual reflection (see below).



Individual Reflection (5% — part of project grade)

After your group presentation, each student will submit a brief individual reflection (approximately 1–2 pages) during finals week. The reflection should address: What did your group explore, and what did you personally contribute? What would you do differently if you had more time or resources? What is one thing you learned from another group's presentation that genuinely surprised or stayed with you?

This reflection is your opportunity to demonstrate your own thinking independent of the group grade. It is graded on substance and engagement, not length.



Research Participation (5%)

All students are expected to learn firsthand about the research process through participation in research experiments, **completing three hours (credits) of research participation during the semester** (for more information, see [link redacted]). If you do not wish to participate in research studies, you have two alternatives: a) Attend a colloquium (and write a summary) or b) Research Article Summary. **This requirement is worth 5% of your final grade.** **Regardless of what format you choose, it is due by Dec 8.**

Grading Structure

Component	Points	% of Grade
Exams (3 × 75 pts each)	225	45%
Reading Quizzes (10 × 10 pts each, lowest 2 dropped)	100	20%
Group Project — Presentation	75	15%
Group Project — Individual Reflection	25	5%
In-Class Activities (13/16 completed)	50	10%
Research Participation	25	5%
TOTAL	500	100%

Grade Scale:

A (93–100%)	A– (90–92%)	B+ (87–89%)	B (83–86%)	B– (80–82%)	C+ (77–79%)
C (73–76%)	C– (70–72%)	D (60–69%)	F (Below 60%)		

Course Calendar

Note: Topics and readings are subject to change with advance notice. Exam dates are fixed.

#	Date	Topic	Readings	Due
1	Aug 28	Course Introduction & Psychology as a Science		Quiz 0
2	Sep 1	Research Methods Pt. 1	Ch. 1: Why Science Ch. 2: Thinking Like a Psychological Scientist	
3	Sep 4	Research Methods Pt. 2	Ch. 3: Research Designs	Quiz 1 Due
4	Sep 8	Biological Psychology Pt. 1	Ch. 4: Neurons	
5	Sep 11	Biological Psychology Pt. 2	Ch. 5: The Brain & the Nervous System	Quiz 2 Due
6	Sep 15	Sensation & Perception	Ch. 6: Sensation & Perception BBC Article: <i>Why do we see faces in everyday objects</i>	Quiz 3 Due
7	Sep 18	Learning Pt. 1	Ch. 7: The Nature vs Nurture Question Ch. 8: Conditioning & Learning	Project Groups Confirmed
8	Sep 22	Learning Pt. 2	Ch. 9: Factors Influencing Learning The Guardian Article: <i>Social media copies gambling methods to create psychological cravings</i>	Quiz 4 Due
9	Sep 25	Memory Pt. 1	Ch. 10: Memory (Encoding, Storage, Retrieval)	
10	Sep 29	Memory Pt. 2	Ch. 11: Forgetting & Amnesia Video: <i>How reliable is your memory?</i> TED Talk	Quiz 5 Due
11	Oct 2	Catch-Up / Review	Review Sessions 2–10	Project Group Meet-up #1
12	Oct 6	MIDTERM 1	Covers Sessions 2–10	
13	Oct 9	Cognition & Intelligence	Ch. 12: Judgment & Decision-Making NYT Article: <i>Don't Blink! The Hazards of Confidence</i>	Quiz 6 Due
14	Oct 13	NO CLASS MONDAY SCHEDULE		
15	Oct 16	Development Pt. 1	Ch. 13: Cognitive Development in Childhood	
16	Oct 20	Development Pt. 2	Ch. 14: Adolescent Development Ch. 15: Emerging Adulthood	Quiz 7 Due

17	Oct 23	Language	Ch. 16: Language & Language Use Video: <i>The linguistic genius of babies, TED Talk</i>	
18	Oct 27	Emotions & Motivation	Ch. 17: Functions of Emotions Video: <i>The biggest myths about emotions, debunked</i>	Quiz 8 Due
19	Oct 30	Social Psychology Pt. 1	Ch. 18: Intro to Social Psychology	Topic Proposal Due
20	Nov 3	Social Psychology Pt. 2	Ch. 19: Conformity, Obedience & Groups	
21	Nov 6	Minority Stress & The Psychology of Bias	Ch. 20: Prejudice, Discrimination & Stereotyping	Quiz 9 Due
22	Nov 10	Catch-Up/ Review	Review Sessions 13-21	Project Group Meet-up #2
23	Nov 13	MIDTERM 2	Covers Session 13-21	
24	Nov 17	Personality	Ch. 21 + 22: Personality Traits & Assessment	Quiz 10
25	Nov 20	Psychological Disorders Pt. 1	Ch. 23: History of Mental Illness Ch. 24: Anxiety & Related Disorders	
26	Nov 24	Psychological Disorders Pt. 2	Ch. 25: Mood Disorders Ch. 26: Schizophrenia Spectrum Video: <i>A tale of mental illness TED Talk</i>	Quiz 11 Due Presentation Slides Due (Draft)
27	Dec 1	Clinical Psychology & Treatment	Ch. 27: Therapeutic Orientations Ch. 28: Psychopharmacology Article: <i>Millions Already Turn to AI for Therapy. Is It Safe?</i>	Quiz 12
28	Dec 4	Group Presentations (Day 1)	—	Presentations
29	Dec 8	Group Presentations (Day 2)	—	Presentations
FINAL	Dec 15	Final Exam 1:30–3:30 pm	Covers Sessions 24-27	Individual Project Reflection Due

I am looking forward to thinking alongside you this semester.
— Alison

